One such 1.5 million-year-old, 12-tonne rock stands at the gate of my hotel; it took a month to chisel the words 'Cheetahgarh Resort & Spa, Bera—A WelcomHeritage Resort' on its face. Bera is one of several villages around the dam on the Jawai River, and the Jawai region is synonymous with leopards—an estimated 50 or 60 in the Bera area. My chances of seeing one are apparently 95-100 per cent. That high, for this shyest of cats? It's hard to believe. Wildlife safaris are largely about patience and luck, and avoiding disappointment by not setting your heart on one particular thing.

My Lake View room at Cheetahgarh is one of 20 aesthetic and well-appointed rooms. I step out onto my balcony at 4.30 am for no reason. Other than the faintest shine of water under lamp-like Venus, the world is just folds of rich velvet darkness. Rotela Lake's herons and kingfishers are asleep, the two crocodiles are still. I'm glad not to be out on foot—no leopard has attacked a human here in hundreds of years, but I'd rather not be the inaugural statistic. Plus, the place is bristling with kraits, Russell's vipers, saw-scaled vipers, and cobras. The hotel insists you use their buggy after daylight hours.

At 5.30 am, I meet naturalist Varghese Jain, and Bhawani Singh, tracker-driver extraordinaire and among the coolest of Jawai's cats. Under a flush of dawn, we drive past delicate stalks of sesame and fields of *jauhar*, to the abandoned mine. Bhawani Singh is looking for his favourite leopard, Neelam, in her favourite haunts, but the peacocks and monkeys aren't alarm calling. She's not in the mine this morning. We try another area full of hardy dhauk trees (*Anogeissus pendula*)





and *palash* (flame of the forest), occasionally passing through gates of bundled branches and twigs that keep cattle in or out. All the land in this area is privately owned, and conservation is privately run. Hotels and camps have mushroomed among the fields.

A red-wattled lapwing flaps past, a kite sits in a tree, a little silverbill looks around near one of the enormous cacti (*Euphorbia caducifolia*). Bhawani drives straight up a huge rock without batting an eyelid, and we get a dazzling 360-degree view, though not of a leopard.

In a third area, he scans the land, and points: "There's Neelam." I deploy my best X-ray vision and see rocks and trees and some power lines. He guns the engine and gets us closer. I still see rocks and trees and some power lines—in my defence, that's the whole point of animal camouflage. Finally, voilà.

Leopards are arguably the most beautiful of big cats, and Neelam is a particularly beautiful leopard. She's sprawled on a rock in the shade of a dhauk, looking over